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UPSC Intel · Daily Brief

THURSDAY, 22 OCTOBER 2026

20 must-know stories, 22 Prelims facts, 15 editorials and 12 explainers, picked from 890 stories reported. Each item links to its source; notes quote the reports.

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MUST-KNOW

High-yield stories: make notes on these. Grouped by syllabus area.

Polity & Constitution

GS2 MAKE NOTES

"Strong States Contribute to a Strong Union; Cooperative Governance Transforms Constitutional Ideals into Public Good": Vice-President

The 23rd Law Commission of India today convened a National Conference on "Co-operative Federalism and Law Reforms: National and State Perspectives" at Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi, bringing together national and State law-reform institutions, jurists, former judges, legal scholars, policymakers, law students, members of the Bar and academia to strengthen dialogue and collaboration on law reform within India's federal framework. Inaugurating the Conference, the Vice-President said that India's greatest strength lies in its unity in diversity, with the Constitution providing the framework to balance the strength of the Union with the responsibilities and legitimate autonomy of the States.

When: 2026-10-22 · **Where:** Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi · **Who:** Vice-President and Union Minister of State for Law and Justice Shri Arjun Ram Meghwal · **Prelims:** The 23rd Law Commission of India convened the National Conference.; The conference was held at Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi.; The theme of the conference was Co-operative Federalism and Law Reforms: National and State Perspectives.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Highlights the importance of institutional dialogue between national and State law reform bodies.; Stresses the elimination of outdated laws through systematic inter-State consultations and sharing of best practices.*

Static — The Law Commission of India is a non-statutory body constituted by a notification of the Ministry of Law and Justice to carry out legal research and recommend law reforms. The first Law Commission of independent India was established in 1955, and subsequent commissions are reconstituted periodically every three years. Cooperative federalism in India denotes a horizontal and vertical relationship between the Centre and States where they cooperate to resolve common problems.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution, Governance & Policy

PIB: read the source

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Information Technology Rules

The Punjab and Haryana High Court held that informing a user is an essential requirement under natural justice when blocking social media pages. The ruling came in a petition by Haryana 24 News Network Private Limited after Meta blocked its page following a police order. Justice Tribhuvan Dahiya noted that the IT Act and 2021 Rules do not explicitly mandate a pre-decisional hearing, but users are directly affected. The court stated that a post-decisional hearing before a grievance officer is meaningless unless the user knows about the action and the government's reasons. The bench read the obligation to furnish a copy of the government intimation to the affected user into Rule 3(2) of the 2021 Rules. The court also ruled that the Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP), Yamunanagar, was not authorised to issue the blocking order. The rules prescribe that the authorised officer must be of a rank not below that of an Inspector General of Police (IGP). Consequently, the high court directed the SSP to ensure the news network's social media page is restored within 24 hours.

When: August 21 · **Where:** Haryana · **Who:** Justice Tribhuvan Dahiya, Haryana 24 News Network Private Limited, Meta, Haryana Police, SSP Yamunanagar · **Prelims:** The case involved Haryana 24 News Network Private Limited and Meta.; The blocking order was initially issued by the Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP), Yamunanagar.; The rules require the authorised officer to be of a rank not below that of an Inspector General of Police (IGP).

> ***Why it matters —*** *Strengthens procedural safeguards and natural justice for digital content creators against arbitrary state censorship.; Clarifies jurisdictional limits by affirming that only officers of the rank of IGP or above can order content blocking under the rules.*

Static — The Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, regulate digital news, social media intermediaries, and OTT platforms in India. Intermediaries are entities that store or transmit data on behalf of third parties, enjoying statutory safe harbor protections under Section 79 of the IT Act, 2000. The principles of natural justice are non-statutory principles of fairness, including the right to a fair hearing (audi alteram partem) and the rule against bias.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Act/Bill/Rules

hindustantimes.com: read the source

GS2 MAKE NOTES

What Should the State Know? Rethinking Government Data Power under the DPDP Act

It is in the news due to ongoing debates on state surveillance, data exemptions, and citizen privacy under the DPDP Act. The article discusses the implications of government data powers and exemptions under the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act.

When: 2026-10-22 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Government agencies and citizens · **Prelims:** The legislation discussed is the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Crucial for understanding the balance between citizen privacy and state security.; Important for GS-2 Polity and Governance syllabus regarding statutory frameworks and fundamental rights.*

Static — The Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act provides the legal framework for processing digital personal data in India. The Act aims to protect individual privacy while recognizing the need to process personal data for lawful purposes. It establishes the Data Protection Board of India to adjudicate non-compliance and enforce provisions of the Act.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Act/Bill/Rules

SCC Online: read the source · also reported by IT Voice Media, Business Standard

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Pre-trial detention cannot become punishment without trial: Supreme Court

The Supreme Court ruled that prolonged pre-trial detention cannot become punishment without trial, protecting personal liberty and speedy trial rights under Article 21. The observation was made by a bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu while granting regular bail in a corruption case linked to the Jal Jeevan Mission. The Court stated that the seriousness of allegations regarding large-scale financial irregularities cannot alone justify keeping an accused in custody indefinitely. The investigation against appellants Mahesh Chandra Joshi and Mukesh Pathak was complete and chargesheets had been filed. The prosecution evidence relied on documents and electronic records already secured by investigators, removing the need for further custodial interrogation or recovery. Joshi had been in jail for over five months since May 7, 2026, and Pathak for nearly eight months since February 18, 2026, without the trial beginning. The case involves 22 accused, 3 chargesheets, 124 witnesses, and around 20,000 pages of evidence, indicating the trial would take considerable time. The appellants had already secured bail in connected proceedings, and several co-accused had also received bail or interim protection.

When: 2026-10-22 · **Where:** New Delhi and Rajasthan · **Who:** Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu, Mahesh Chandra Joshi, Mukesh Pathak · **Prelims:** Mahesh Chandra Joshi and Mukesh Pathak were granted regular bail by the Supreme Court.; The case involves alleged irregularities in tenders worth hundreds of crores under the Jal Jeevan Mission in Rajasthan.; The case features 22 accused persons, three chargesheets, 124 prosecution witnesses, and 192 documents running into 20,000 pages.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Reinforces the constitutional principle that 'bail is the rule and jail is the exception' even in serious economic offences.; Highlights systemic delays in the Indian criminal justice system involving voluminous documents and numerous witnesses.*

Static — Article 21 of the Constitution guarantees the right to life and personal liberty, which the Supreme Court has repeatedly interpreted to include the right to a speedy trial. Bail is a judicial remedy meant to ensure the presence of the accused during trial while upholding the cardinal principle of criminal jurisprudence that an accused is presumed innocent until proven guilty. Under the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC) or Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), prolonged detention during investigation or trial serves as a key ground for granting bail when delays are not attributable to the accused.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment

Bar & Bench: read the source · free copy on freepressjournal.in

Governance & Policy

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Pradhan Mantri Samajik Sahayata Yojana

The Union Cabinet approved the continuation of the National Social Assistance Programme for five years from 2026-27 to 2030-31 with an outlay of Rs. 53,428 crore. The programme has been renamed the Pradhan Mantri Samajik Sahayata Yojana with its four component schemes also receiving new names. While old-age, widow pensions, and family benefits continue in existing forms, the disability pension underwent major structural revisions. The disability pension threshold was lowered from 80 percent severe disability to the 40 percent benchmark disability under the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016. The minimum age requirement of 18 years for the disability pension was removed, making eligible individuals able to receive assistance from birth. Central assistance for the disability pension was increased to Rs. 375 per month for ages up to 79 and Rs. 625 per month for those 80 and above. Beneficiaries under the disability pension component expanded significantly from 8.33 lakh to 27.48 lakh people across all States and UTs. Total programme coverage across all components reached 3.20 crore beneficiaries, up from the previous 3.09 crore.

When: 2026-10-14 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Union Cabinet, Department of Rural Development · **Prelims:** Total outlay for the programme from 2026-27 to 2030-31 is Rs. 53,428 crore.; The programme was originally launched on August 15, 1995.; Disability pension central assistance is Rs. 375 per month for age 0-79 and Rs. 625 for age 80 and above.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Extends social security coverage to children under 18 with benchmark disabilities who were previously excluded due to age limits.; Aligns central welfare schemes with the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 by adopting the 40 percent disability threshold.*

Static — The National Social Assistance Programme was originally launched on August 15, 1995, as a centrally sponsored welfare scheme providing financial support to below-poverty-line households. The programme gives effect to Article 41 of the Constitution of India, directing the State to provide public assistance for old age, sickness, and disablement. The Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016, enacted to implement the UN Convention, defines a benchmark disability as not less than 40 percent of a specified disability across 21 categories.

Syllabus: GS2: Governance & Policy, Social Justice & Welfare · Prelims angle: Scheme, Data/Stats

PIB: read the source · free copy on ddnews.gov.in

GS2 GS3 MAKE NOTES

PM E-DRIVE Scheme

The Press Information Bureau released an announcement regarding the PM E-DRIVE Scheme. An official update was released concerning the PM E-DRIVE Scheme.

When: 2026-10-22 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Press Information Bureau · **Prelims:** PM E-DRIVE scheme relates to electric vehicle promotion.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Relevant for government initiatives promoting clean energy and decarbonization of the transport sector.; Important for assessing industrial policy and transition towards electric mobility in India.*

Static — The PM E-DRIVE (Electric Drive Revolution in Innovative Vehicle Enhancement) scheme was approved to accelerate electric vehicle adoption and establish charging infrastructure across India. It is administered by the Ministry of Heavy Industries to succeed the FAME (Faster Adoption and Manufacturing of Electric Vehicles) schemes. Key focus areas include financial incentives for electric two-wheelers, three-wheelers, ambulances, trucks, and public transport buses.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Scheme

Press Information Bureau: read the source

International Relations

GS2 MAKE NOTES

PM Modi, Polish PM Donald Tusk agree to deepen cooperation in defence, space, nuclear energy

India and Poland agreed to deepen cooperation in defense, space, and nuclear energy to double bilateral trade to $12 billion by 2030. The meeting was driven by shared economic growth and Poland's ongoing military modernization campaign spending nearly 5% of its GDP. The core discussion focused on co-development and co-production in strategic sectors, trusted supply chains, and critical minerals independence. Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk noted current two-way trade stands at $6.3 billion with Indian investments reaching $3 billion. Both nations agreed to develop partnerships in critical minerals, coal gasification, and a bilateral startup bridge for AI, fintech, and cybersecurity. A business delegation of nearly 100 Polish companies will participate in business forums in New Delhi and Bengaluru. The two sides are finalizing an agreement on secure information exchanges and mutual protection of classified information to boost defense collaboration. Regional issues were also discussed, with Poland appreciating India's proposal for a Russia-Ukraine ceasefire and diplomatic solutions.

When: 2026-10-22 · **Where:** New Delhi and Warsaw · **Who:** Narendra Modi, Donald Tusk, Sibi George · **Prelims:** Current bilateral trade between India and Poland is around $6.3 billion.; Indian investments in Poland have grown to $3 billion.; Poland's WB Group supplied Warmate loitering munitions to the Indian Army.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Strengthens India's defense manufacturing through co-development and co-production opportunities with European firms.; Aims to double bilateral trade to $12 billion by 2030 through diversified investments and trusted supply chains.*

Static — India-Poland diplomatic relations were established in 1954 and have traditionally been friendly, underscored by mutual respect and historical people-to-people connections. Poland is a central European nation and member of the European Union (EU) and NATO, currently undertaking a massive military modernization program. Bilateral trade between India and Poland spans sectors such as pharmaceuticals, IT, engineering goods, and agricultural products.

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations, Infrastructure & Energy, Defence

Hindustan Times: read the source · also reported by ET Now, PIB, Times of India, All India Radio (NewsOnAir), BusinessLine, CNBC TV18, Republic World

GS2 GS3 MAKE NOTES

India-EU FTA may come into effect in January-March, says Piyush Goyal

Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal stated that the India-European Union Free Trade Agreement could become operational within the next four to five months. Goyal urged Indian and German businesses to begin preparations immediately by exchanging product samples, quality requirements, and pricing rather than waiting for the deal to take effect. The minister noted that the trade pact, finalised earlier this year after negotiations concluded on January 27, is expected to be signed before the end of the calendar year. Goyal highlighted that the agreement took twenty years to negotiate, with the finalisation accomplished during the last thirteen months due to joint commitment. He invited German businesses to explore opportunities in India across manufacturing, investment, technology, and skill development to enhance bilateral competitiveness. The minister emphasized supply-chain resilience, economic security, the green transition, and emerging technologies as critical areas for closer India-Germany collaboration. Goyal acknowledged the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, German Chancellor Friedrich Merz, and EU Trade Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis in advancing the partnership.

When: 2026-10-22 · **Where:** Berlin, Germany · **Who:** Piyush Goyal, Friedrich Merz, Valdis Dombrovskis, Narendra Modi · **Prelims:** The conclusion of negotiations for the India-EU FTA was announced on January 27.; Piyush Goyal serves as the Union Commerce and Industry Minister of India.; Valdis Dombrovskis serves as the European Union Trade Commissioner.

> ***Why it matters —*** *It signals the imminent operationalization of a massive trade deal covering India and the 27-nation EU block, often described as a pivotal economic pact.; It encourages early business-to-business engagement between Indian and German enterprises to maximize utilization of upcoming tariff concessions.*

Static — A Free Trade Agreement (FTA) is an international treaty between two or more economies to reduce or eliminate import tariffs and non-tariff barriers on traded goods and services. The European Union operates as a single internal market with a common commercial policy, meaning individual member states do not negotiate separate trade pacts once the EU concludes an FTA. Bilateral trade pacts involving the EU require extensive legal reviews, translation into all official EU languages, and approval by the European Parliament and the Council of the European Union.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: International Relations · Prelims angle: Agreement/MoU

Business Standard: read the source · free copy on msn.com · also reported by Economic Times

GS2 MAKE NOTES

US Energy Push, Quad & Bilateral Trade Gridlock in Focus as Marco Rubio Visits India

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio visited India to discuss bilateral trade, energy cooperation, and strategic security ties. The visit was triggered by the need to resolve ongoing trade gridlocks and advance the ongoing bilateral trade agreement negotiations. Core discussions centered on reciprocal tariffs under Section 301, agricultural access, and civil nuclear cooperation under the Shanti Bill. Rubio toured the Reliance Industries oil refinery complex in Jamnagar, Gujarat, to focus on heavy crude refining and Venezuelan and US crude supplies. Strategic talks covered technological infrastructure, satellite communications, counterterrorism cooperation, and Quad maritime domain awareness initiatives. Experts reviewed diplomatic approaches to the Russia-Ukraine conflict, critical supply chain security, talent mobility, H-1B visas, and domestic political timelines.

When: 2026-10-22 · **Where:** India and Jamnagar, Gujarat · **Who:** Marco Rubio, Michael Kugelman, Dr. Ajay Srivastava, Pramit Pal Chaudhuri, Alexander Slater · **Prelims:** Marco Rubio visited India in his capacity as US Secretary of State.; Discussions included reciprocal tariffs under Section 301.; Civil nuclear cooperation was discussed under the Shanti Bill.

> ***Why it matters —*** *It highlights ongoing efforts to resolve long-standing trade disagreements including Section 301 tariffs and agricultural market access.; It reinforces energy security cooperation through major refining partnerships and diversified crude supply integration.*

Static — The Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad) is an informal strategic forum comprising India, the US, Japan, and Australia, focused on ensuring a free and open Indo-Pacific region. Bilateral trade discussions between India and the United States often involve complex market access negotiations, intellectual property rights, and tariff frameworks governed by respective domestic laws. Section 301 of the US Trade Act of 1974 allows the United States Trade Representative to investigate and take action against foreign trade practices that burden US commerce.

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations

indiatoday.in: read the source

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Makkah defence pact: Should India be worried?

The signing of the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement has raised questions about its potential complications for India's regional interests. Saudi Arabia, Türkiye, and Pakistan have signed the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement, boosting Pakistan's strategic footprint in West Asia and its military ties with Türkiye. The Makkah Joint Defence Agreement between Saudi Arabia, Türkiye, and Pakistan could expand Pakistan’s strategic role in West Asia and strengthen its military ties with Türkiye, complicating India’s regional interests.

When: 2026-10-22 · **Where:** West Asia · **Who:** Saudi Arabia, Türkiye, Pakistan · **Prelims:** The agreement is named the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement.; The participating nations are Saudi Arabia, Türkiye, and Pakistan.

Why it matters — *It tests India's diplomatic balancing act in West Asia amid changing regional alliances.; It enhances Pakistan's strategic footprint and military cooperation outside South Asia.*

Static — Saudi Arabia is a key partner for India in West Asia, focusing on energy security, trade, and diaspora welfare. Türkiye and Pakistan have historically maintained close bilateral and military ties, often coordinating on regional platforms. India's foreign policy in West Asia relies on balancing relations with major regional powers like Saudi Arabia, UAE, Iran, and Israel.

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations, Defence · Prelims angle: Agreement/MoU

Frontline: read the source

Health

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court tells Centre to issue public protocol to curb malpractice in stem cell therapy for autism spectrum disorder

The Supreme Court directed the Union Health Ministry to issue a public protocol within six weeks restricting stem cell therapy for autism spectrum disorder. The directive follows widespread malpractice and commercial exploitation by clinics offering unproven stem cell procedures as routine clinical treatment. The bench reiterated that stem cell therapy for autism lacks scientific validity and fails the reasonable standard of care owed to patients. Patients and caregivers cannot demand the procedure clinically, though participation in approved clinical trials remains permitted without therapeutic misconception. Interventions involving more than minimal manipulation fall under CDSCO, while minimal manipulation is regulated by the Department of Health Research. The Centre will launch an ICMR-funded multicentre randomised controlled trial across two tertiary sites in North and South India within six months. Online portals must be set up within four to six weeks for stakeholder suggestions and maintaining medical records of pre-existing patients. Pre-existing patients may temporarily continue treatment under strict monitoring, but no new patients can be inducted outside approved research frameworks.

When: October 2026 · **Where:** New Delhi · **Who:** Supreme Court bench of Justices J B Pardiwala and R Mahadevan, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, CDSCO, and ICMR · **Prelims:** Procedures with more than minimal stem cell manipulation are regulated by CDSCO under New Drugs and Clinical Trial Rules, 2019.; Minimal manipulation procedures fall under the Department of Health Research's National Stem Cell Research Regulation Committee.; ICMR is funding a multicentre randomised controlled trial at two tertiary care sites in North and South India.

Why it matters — *Protects vulnerable patients and families from exploitative and unscientific medical commercialisation.; Demarcates regulatory boundaries between CDSCO and the Department of Health Research for cell-based therapies.*

Static — Stem cells are unspecialised human cells capable of self-renewal and differentiating into specialised cell types with diverse physiological functions. Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) under the Ministry of Health discharges regulatory functions over drugs, cosmetics, and clinical trials under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940. The New Drugs and Clinical Trial Rules, 2019 establish ethical requirements, participant protections, and approval frameworks for clinical trials in India.

Syllabus: GS2: Health, Polity & Constitution, Science & Technology · Prelims angle: Judgment

deccanherald.com: read the source

Economy

GS3 MAKE NOTES

RBI October Rate Hike, Inflation and Tightening Stance

The Reserve Bank of India's Monetary Policy Committee unanimously raised the repo rate by 25 basis points to 5.5%. The MPC shifted its policy stance from neutral to calibrated tightening, signaling that rate cuts are off the table in the near term. Headline CPI inflation is projected to touch the upper tolerance band of 6% in Q3 and stay above 5% for the next two quarters. Inflation is broadening beyond food and fuel, with the share of CPI-basket commodities having inflation above 4% rising from 20% to 37%. Key inflation drivers include deficient monsoons, El Niño disruptions, rising crude oil prices due to the West Asia conflict, and rupee depreciation. External members like Dr Nagesh Kumar and Prof Ram Singh opposed the aggressive stance shift, warning about supply-side drivers and risks to growth. Hawkish members like Poonam Gupta and Saugata Bhattacharya favored firm pre-emptive action to preserve the credibility of the inflation-targeting framework. The RBI revised its FY27 inflation forecast upward, with headline inflation projected at 5.2% and core inflation at 4.4%.

When: 2026-10-22 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Reserve Bank of India Monetary Policy Committee · **Prelims:** Repo rate raised by 25 basis points to 5.5%.; Policy stance shifted from neutral to calibrated tightening.; Headline CPI projected to touch 6% in Q3.

Why it matters — *Signals an end to expectations of near-term rate cuts, impacting borrowing costs for consumers and businesses.; Reflects the central bank's commitment to prioritizing price stability amid persistent supply shocks and rising inflation expectations.*

Static — The Monetary Policy Committee is a statutory body constituted under Section 45ZB of the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934 to determine the policy interest rate required to achieve the inflation target. The MPC consists of six members: the RBI Governor (Chairperson), one RBI Deputy Governor in charge of monetary policy, one official nominated by the RBI Board, and three external members appointed by the central government. External members hold office for a period of four years and are not eligible for reappointment.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

Vajiram & Ravi: read the source · also reported by Economic Times, ET Government, Asianet Newsable, boldnewsonline.com, Swarajyamag

GS3 MAKE NOTES

The RBI and its growing fiscal role

The Reserve Bank of India organised the two-day international seminar SAMVAD 2026 in New Delhi on October 19 and 20 to discuss global financial stability and emerging risks. Policymakers and experts highlighted concerns over growing geopolitical tensions, increasing use of artificial intelligence, and risks from non-bank financial institutions. RBI Deputy Governor Poonam Gupta noted that financial stability has become a policy objective, focusing on the broader financial system rather than individual institutions. Former RBI Governor Shaktikanta Das cautioned that prolonged conflicts, global fragmentation, and untested AI valuations increase sovereign debt stress and financial vulnerabilities. Department of Economic Affairs Secretary Anuradha Thakur stated that India faces global uncertainty from a position of macroeconomic stability with a credible fiscal trajectory. Discussions on digital payments examined challenges surrounding AI-driven transactions, cross-border payment systems, and the need for security, speed, and interoperability. Chief Economic Adviser V Anantha Nageswaran emphasised that financial inclusion must move beyond access toward effective usage and greater economic resilience. The RBI made a record surplus transfer of Rs 2.87 lakh crore to the Centre, highlighting its growing fiscal significance and raising questions about central bank independence.

When: October 19 and 20, 2026 · **Where:** New Delhi · **Who:** Reserve Bank of India, Poonam Gupta, Shaktikanta Das, Anuradha Thakur, V Anantha Nageswaran, Sanjay Malhotra, Nirmala Sitharaman · **Prelims:** The SAMVAD 2026 seminar was held in New Delhi on October 19 and 20.; The RBI transferred a record surplus of Rs 2.87 lakh crore to the Centre.; Sanjay Malhotra is the RBI Governor who delivered the welcome address at the seminar.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Highlights the evolving mandate of central banks in addressing systemic risks like artificial intelligence and climate change.; Shed light on India's macroeconomic stability and robust digital payment systems amid global uncertainty.*

Static — The Reserve Bank of India was established on April 1, 1935, in accordance with the provisions of the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934. The central bank is fully owned by the Government of India and is managed by a central board of directors appointed by the government. The primary mandate of the RBI includes regulating the issue of bank notes, keeping reserves to secure monetary stability, and operating the currency and credit system.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

The Hindu: read the source · *free copy on msn.com*

Agriculture & Allied

GS3 MAKE NOTES

30% of India’s croplands technically suitable for solar agrovoltaics: Pralhad Joshi

Union Minister Pralhad Joshi stated that an estimated 47.5 million hectares, representing about 30% of India's 160 million hectares of cropland, are technically suitable for agrivoltaics. The announcement was made during the inauguration of the 7th edition of the AgriVoltaics World Conference 2026 at Bharat Mandapam in Delhi. A deployment scenario covering 16 million hectares estimates an annual electricity generation of 12,775 TWh, potentially exceeding India's projected electricity demand for 2050. The new PM-Kusum 2.0 scheme will include a dedicated agrivoltaics component to expand solar capacity and benefit farmers. Elevated and tilted structures make agrivoltaic plants 25 to 30 percent more expensive than conventional ground-mounted solar installations. The government aims to bridge this cost gap by supporting AgriPV capacity creation under the upcoming phases. Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan emphasized that any AgriPV policy must cater to small and marginal farmers, who make up over 85% of India's farming community with an average landholding of 0.96 hectares. A Decision-Making Tool developed by the India Agrivoltaics Alliance and an AgriPV policy handbook were launched during the conference.

When: 2026-10-22 · **Where:** Bharat Mandapam, Delhi · **Who:** Pralhad Joshi, Shivraj Singh Chouhan, The Energy and Resources Institute, India Agrivoltaics Alliance · **Prelims:** TERI estimated 47.5 million hectares of Indian cropland is technically suitable for agrivoltaics.; AgriPV plants are 25-30% more expensive than conventional ground-mounted solar installations due to elevated and tilted structures.; India's average landholding size is 0.96 hectares, and small and marginal farmers constitute more than 85% of the farming community.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Highlights the dual-use potential of agricultural land to generate renewable energy without halting crop production.; Addresses India's future clean energy targets and electricity demand projections through innovative solar deployment.*

Static — Agrivoltaics or AgriPV combines agricultural production and solar photovoltaic electricity generation on the same piece of land simultaneously. The PM-KUSUM (Pradhan Mantri Kisan Urja Suraksha evam Utthaan Mahabhiyan) scheme was launched by the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) to provide financial and water security to farmers. Small and marginal farmers in India hold landholdings of less than 2 hectares, constituting a major share of the country's agrarian demographic.

Syllabus: GS3: Agriculture & Allied, Infrastructure & Energy · Prelims angle: Scheme

Hindustan Times: read the source

Environment & Ecology

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Breach of 1.5 degrees Celsius temperature threshold now 'unavoidable', says Emissions Gap Report

The UN Environment Programme's Emissions Gap Report warns that breaching the 1.5-degree Celsius warming threshold is now imminent and unavoidable due to insufficient action. Current climate policies project a temperature rise of 2.8 degrees Celsius this century, while new pledges would still lead to 2.6 degrees Celsius of warming. Among major emitters, China, Indonesia, and the United States saw emissions rise in 2025, with the US increase driven by coal resurgence and AI data center expansion. US President Donald Trump's withdrawal from the Paris climate accord and subsequent gutting of environmental regulations have worsened the global climate outlook. Exceeding 1.5 degrees Celsius risks triggering irreversible tipping points such as coral reef loss, ice sheet retreat, and the Amazon Rainforest turning into grassland. The UN outlines a best-case scenario where warming peaks at 1.7 to 1.8 degrees Celsius mid-century before falling back to 1.5 Celsius by 2100. Achieving this recovery requires steep emissions cuts of 69% by 2040 relative to 2025 levels and removing 330 billion metric tons of carbon dioxide.

When: 2026-10-22 · **Where:** Global · **Who:** UN Environment Programme (UNEP), Bill Hare, Antonio Guterres, Inger Andersen, Donald Trump · **Prelims:** The report was published by the United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP).; Current climate policies project an average temperature rise of 2.8 degrees Celsius within this century.; Some 167 countries have submitted climate action plans to the UN covering 83% of global greenhouse gas emissions.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Highlights the growing gap between national climate promises and actual implementation of emission reduction policies.; Draws attention to the severe risks of climate tipping points and catastrophic weather extremes affecting vulnerable populations globally.*

Static — The United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) was founded in June 1972 following the landmark UN Conference on the Human Environment held in Stockholm. UNEP is headquartered in Nairobi, Kenya, and acts as the leading global environmental authority that sets the global environmental agenda. The Paris Agreement, adopted in 2015 at COP21, legally binds parties to hold the increase in global average temperature to well below 2 degrees Celsius above pre-industrial levels.

Syllabus: GS3: Environment & Ecology · Prelims angle: Report/Index

dw.com: read the source · also reported by ForumIAS, Nature World News, ESG News.earth

GS1 GS3 MAKE NOTES

El Nino could be unprecedented, may rise to 3.8 degC above average between Nov-Jan: WMO

The World Meteorological Organization stated that the current El Nino event could be unprecedented in strength and rise to 3.8 degC above average between November 2026 and January 2027. A peak is expected in December 2026, which will disrupt global weather patterns and cause higher temperatures and weaker rainfall in south and southeast Asia, including India. WMO declares an El Nino when the sea surface temperature anomaly in the tropical Pacific reaches 0.5 degC and higher. A very strong El Nino can trigger severe drought in some regions and heavy rainfall or flooding in others, increasing heat across large parts of the world. The United Nations Environment Programme released a report stating that current policies could lead to 2.8 degC global warming above pre-industrial standards within this century. The WMO outlook indicates normal to above-normal maximum and minimum temperatures across South Asia, affecting critical October to December agricultural rainfall. India's southwest monsoon departed on October 15, while northeast monsoon rains began in southern India on the same day, but this seasonal rain is likely to suffer.

When: November 2026 to January 2027 · **Where:** South and Southeast Asia, India, Tropical Pacific · **Who:** World Meteorological Organization (WMO), United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP), Celeste Saulo · **Prelims:** WMO declares an El Nino when the tropical Pacific sea surface temperature anomaly is 0.5 degC and higher.; The southwest monsoon departed India on October 15.; Northeast monsoon rains in southern India began on October 15.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Poses a severe threat to agricultural operations and food security in south and southeast Asia due to weaker rainfall.; Highlights the compounding crisis of long-term global warming alongside extreme cyclic weather anomalies.*

Static — El Nino is a climate pattern described by the abnormal warming of surface waters in the eastern tropical Pacific Ocean. It forms part of the broader oscillation known as the El Nino-Southern Oscillation, influencing global weather and ocean circulation. During an El Nino year, trade winds weaken or blow from west to east, piling warm surface water up against the Americas.

Syllabus: GS1 / GS3: Environment & Ecology, Geography

Hindustan Times: read the source

Science & Technology

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Centre notifies telecom regulatory sandbox rules 2026 to test new technologies

The Central Government has notified the Telecommunications (Regulatory Sandbox) Rules, 2026, allowing entities to test new telecom technologies in a controlled environment. The rules were notified by the Department of Telecommunications under the Ministry of Communications and came into effect on October 21, 2026. The framework is introduced under the Telecommunications Act, 2023, to enable testing of innovative telecom products, networks, and services with regulatory exemptions. Eligible applicants include authorised telecom entities, companies, partnership firms, statutory bodies, Indian citizens, and research institutions recognised by the Department of Science and Technology. Applicants must submit proposals with preliminary lab testing reports and a non-refundable processing fee of Rs 10,000. The government may grant exemptions from specific authorisation, spectrum assignment, and TRAI Act provisions, requiring prior consultation with TRAI for TRAI Act exemptions. A regulatory sandbox can operate for an initial maximum of 24 months, with extensions of up to 12 months at a time permitted. Safeguards require obtaining prior consent from test users, prohibiting charging test users fees, and ensuring compliance with data protection laws.

When: October 21, 2026 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Department of Telecommunications, Ministry of Communications, Telecom Regulatory Authority of India · **Prelims:** Processing fee for sandbox proposal: Rs 10,000; Initial maximum operational period of a regulatory sandbox: 24 months; Maximum extension period for a sandbox at a time: up to 12 months

> ***Why it matters —*** *Provides a controlled pathway for Indian startups and researchers to validate innovative telecom technologies before commercial deployment.; Builds strong consumer safeguards by mandating user consent, free participation, and strict adherence to data protection laws.*

Static — A regulatory sandbox creates a controlled, live testing environment where legal and regulatory relaxations are granted to try out innovative technologies or business models safely. The Telecommunications Act, 2023 modernises India's legal framework for the telecom sector, replacing older colonial-era legislations like the Indian Telegraph Act, 1885. The Department of Telecommunications functions under the Ministry of Communications, Government of India, and handles policy, licensing, and coordination of all telecom services.

Syllabus: GS3: Science & Technology, Infrastructure & Energy, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Act/Bill/Rules

msn.com: read the source · also reported by Adda247

Internal Security

GS2 GS3 MAKE NOTES

Implementation of Section 51A of UAPA, 1967: Updates to UNSC's 1267/ 1989 ISIL (Da'esh) & Al-Qaida Sanctions List: Amendment of 03 Entries

The update was triggered by recent amendments made by the United Nations Security Council to its 1267/1989 ISIL and Al-Qaida Sanctions List. SEBI issued circular updates directing market intermediaries to implement Section 51A of the UAPA regarding three amended entries on the UNSC ISIL and Al-Qaida Sanctions List.

When: 2026-10-22 · **Where:** India · **Who:** SEBI · **Prelims:** Act involved: Unlawful Activities Prevention Act, 1967; Specific Section: Section 51A; UNSC List: 1267/1989 ISIL (Da'esh) & Al-Qaida Sanctions List

> ***Why it matters —*** *Ensures India's compliance with United Nations Security Council counter-terrorism resolutions.; Strengthens the regulatory framework of Indian financial markets against terror financing.*

Static — The Unlawful Activities Prevention Act (UAPA) of 1967 is India's primary anti-terror legislation aimed at prevention of unlawful activities associations in India. Section 51A of the UAPA empowers the Central Government to freeze, seize or attach funds and financial assets of individuals and entities suspected of terrorist activities. The UNSC 1267/1989 Sanctions Committee oversees implementation of asset freezes, travel bans, and arms embargoes against ISIL and Al-Qaida.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Internal Security, International Relations, Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Act/Bill/Rules

SEBI: read the source

Defence

GS3 MAKE NOTES

BrahMos-NG prototype by 2027-28, 1,500-km range missile on future roadmap: BrahMos chief

BrahMos Aerospace expects to develop the first prototype of its next-generation BrahMos-NG missile by 2027 or 2028. The BrahMos-NG system is currently under development, featuring higher indigenous content, new technologies, and advanced materials. A missile with an extended range of 1,500 km is part of the future roadmap and is currently at the conceptual stage. Foreign countries operating the Sukhoi-30 platform have expressed interest in the air-launched BrahMos and the BrahMos-NG system. BrahMos-NG will be developed first in an airborne configuration. The missile's combat performance, including precise strikes during Operation Sindoor, has driven high foreign military interest. Production units at Hyderabad, Nagpur, and Lucknow are working to complete existing orders from the Indian Armed Forces. The company aims to expand its supply chain sources from 1-2 partners per system to 4-5 sources to boost competition.

When: 2026-10-22 · **Where:** New Delhi · **Who:** Dr. Jaiteerth Joshi · **Prelims:** The first prototype of the BrahMos-NG missile is expected by 2027 or 2028.; The proposed long-term missile range on the roadmap is 1,500 km.; India's defence exports have reached Rs 38,400 crore with a 62.7% annual growth.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Highlights India's push towards indigenous defence manufacturing and self-reliance (Atmanirbhar Bharat).; Expands India's defence export potential with high international interest in the Sukhoi-30 integrated air-launched variants.*

Static — BrahMos is a supersonic cruise missile jointly developed by India (DRDO) and Russia (NPOM), named after two rivers, the Brahmaputra and the Moskva. It operates on a two-stage propulsion system with a solid propellant booster for initial acceleration and a liquid ramjet for supersonic cruise. Originally designed with a range of 290 km in compliance with the Missile Technology Control Regime (MTCR), India's entry into MTCR allowed range extensions beyond 300 km.

Syllabus: GS3: Defence

Economic Times: read the source · *free copy on msn.com*

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Indian Army's new warfare doctrine: Rajnath Singh to unveil how the Army plans to tackle threats from China and Pakistan

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh will release the Indian Army's new land warfare doctrine on October 23, concluding the Army Commanders' Conference. The updated doctrine addresses changes in modern warfare including drones, artificial intelligence, precision strikes, and multi-domain operations. The three-day conference marks the first under Army Chief General Dhiraj Seth and includes commanders-in-chief of all operational and training commands. The new document incorporates lessons learned from the ongoing stand-off with China along the LAC, Operation Sindoor, and conflicts in Ukraine and West Asia. Previous land warfare doctrines were published in 1998, 2004, and December 2018, while the Joint Doctrine for Multi-Domain Operations was issued in August 2025. Operation Sindoor in May 2025 demonstrated the tactical use of artillery and precision-guided munitions against terrorist infrastructure in Pakistan and PoJK. The doctrine emphasizes integrating conventional forces with cyber, space, electronic warfare, unmanned platforms, and digital command systems. New formations like Integrated Battle Groups, Bhairav battalions, Shaktibaan regiments, and Ashni platoons reflect the Army's structural adaptation.

When: October 23, 2026 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Rajnath Singh and General Dhiraj Seth · **Prelims:** The Army's previous land warfare doctrine was released in December 2018.; Operation Sindoor took place in May 2025, targeting terrorist infrastructure in Pakistan and PoJK.; The Joint Doctrine for Multi-Domain Operations was issued by the Integrated Defence Services in August 2025.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Provides a strategic framework for tackling dual-front challenges involving China and Pakistan.; Guides the integration of disruptive technologies like artificial intelligence and unmanned aerial systems into regular combat.*

Static — The Indian Army operates under the Ministry of Defence and is led by the Chief of Army Staff, organized into operational and training commands. Land warfare doctrines serve as overarching strategic guidelines that direct force modernization, capability development, and operational planning. Multi-domain operations doctrine integrates land, air, maritime, space, cyber, and information domains for synchronized military engagement.

Syllabus: GS3: Defence, International Relations, Science & Technology

Economic Times: read the source · *free copy on msn.com*

PRELIMS FACTS

Concrete developments worth a quick read: exercises, pacts, Acts, approvals, schemes, species, verdicts.

SOCIAL JUSTICE & WELFARE SCHEME REPORT/INDEX QUICK READ

Factual Report on PM-DAKSH

A factual report detailing the financial and performance metrics of the PM-DAKSH scheme was published by the Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment. The government released a factual report detailing the implementation, expenditure, and placement outcomes of the PM-DAKSH skill training scheme from 2020 to 2024.

PIB: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY QUICK READ

As A Follow-Up to The Departmental Summit on Water 2026, Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation Organised Virtual Conference on Convergence of JJM 2.0 With 16th Finance Grants for Rural water Supply and Strengthening of O&M Systems

The Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation organised a virtual conference to discuss the convergence of Jal Jeevan Mission 2.0 with 16th Finance Commission grants for strengthening rural water supply and operations and maintenance systems.

PIB: source

POLITY & CONSTITUTION | ACT/BILL/RULES | QUICK READ

Uttarakhand Cabinet approves changes in UCC Rules, 24 other proposals

The Uttarakhand Cabinet approved 25 proposals during a meeting chaired by Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami ahead of the winter Assembly session. The approved proposals include changes to the Uniform Civil Code Rules, a stamp duty one-time settlement scheme, and the creation of an adventure tourism corporation. The core issue addressed involves streamlining administrative approvals, boosting welfare schemes, and amending state acts to remove implementation bottlenecks.

ptinews.com: source

SOCIAL JUSTICE & WELFARE | AGREEMENT/MOU | QUICK READ

Tripartite MoU signed to strengthen livelihood opportunities for Scheduled Tribe youth

A tripartite MoU was signed on October 22, 2026, to strengthen livelihood opportunities and entrepreneurship for Scheduled Tribe youth. The agreement involves the National Scheduled Tribes Finance and Development Corporation, NSIC, and Steel Authority of India Ltd. The initiative focuses on upgrading skills, improving processes, and linking knowledge with funding structures for sustainable livelihoods.

PIB: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS | QUICK READ

12th BRICS Parliamentary Forum to be Held in the Central Hall of Samvidhan Sadan on 26–27 October 2026: Lok Sabha Speaker

The iconic Central Hall and Library Hall of the Parliament complex are being prepared to host the 12th BRICS Parliamentary Forum next week. The event is triggered by India hosting the multilateral parliamentary summit to engage global leaders on key governance and developmental themes. At stake is India's diplomatic outreach, showcasing its cultural heritage, and fostering multilateral parliamentary cooperation among BRICS nations and partners.

Hindustan Times: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY | QUICK READ

Towards Future-Ready Data Leaders: Comprehensive Capacity Building recommendations by Committee in MoSPI

The Committee for Reforming Capacity Building of the Indian Statistical Service (ISS) submitted its report to Dr Saurabh Garg, Secretary, MoSPI. The committee was chaired by P.R. Meshram, Director General (Data Governance), MoSPI, and included senior officers, knowledge partners, and industry experts. The initiative aims to strengthen the training framework for ISS officers to handle next-generation data requirements and contribute to Viksit Bharat 2047.

PIB: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY | SPECIES | PLACE IN NEWS | QUICK READ

Tadoba tiger reserve introduces sensor-based system to manage wildlife waterholes

The Tadoba-Andhari Tiger Reserve in Maharashtra has introduced a sensor-based system on a pilot basis to regulate wildlife waterhole water levels. The initiative addresses the problem of solar-powered pumps continuing to operate after waterholes are full, causing water overflow and excessive groundwater extraction. The core issue is improving wildlife water management efficiently during drought conditions without risking staff safety through manual monitoring.

The Hindu: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY | QUICK READ

UN climate damages fund earmarks $20 million to Nepal for August disaster

The UN Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage approved 20 million US dollars to support Nepal after devastating floods in August. The decision was made at an extraordinary board meeting following an urgent request from Nepal. An ice-and-rock avalanche in the Himalayas on August 26 triggered the floods along the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli rivers.

The Hindu: source

AGRICULTURE & ALLIED | SCHEME | QUICK READ

“Save both people and fields”: Union Minister Shri Shivraj Singh Chouhan launches nationwide ‘Khet Bachao Abhiyan’ from Taraori in Karnal

Union Agriculture and Farmers Welfare Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan launched the nationwide 'Khet Bachao Abhiyan -- Rabi 2026' from Taraori in Karnal district. The campaign aims to promote sustainable farming, improve soil health, encourage judicious use of resources, and strengthen soil and water conservation. The minister warned that imbalanced use of chemical fertilizers and pesticides will ruin the soil's crop-producing ability and impact human health.

PIB: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY | SPECIES | QUICK READ

Nearly all coral reefs risk collapse in 50 years: IUCN

Nearly all shallow-water coral reefs face an extremely high risk of collapse by 2075 due to climate change, according to an IUCN warning. The IUCN classified 96 percent of the planet's coral reef systems as critically endangered in the first global assessment of its kind. Human-driven climate change is warming oceans and increasing damaging bleaching events, which represent the single most consistent threat driving coral decline.

msn.com: source

INFRASTRUCTURE & ENERGY | AGREEMENT/MOU | QUICK READ

NLC India signs MoU for Rs.35,000 crore thermal power plant and other projects in Odisha

NLC India Limited signed Memoranda of Understanding with the Industrial Promotion and Investment Corporation of Odisha Limited. The agreement aims to explore investments in a massive thermal power plant, coal gasification, and mineral processing. The proposed 3,200 MW ultra-supercritical coal-based thermal power plant involves an investment of Rs 35,000 crore.

psuwatch.com: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS | REPORT/INDEX | SCHEME | QUICK READ

India rejects UN rapporteur's 'India-based' label for Dawood Ibrahim's D-Company

India strongly rejected a UN special rapporteur's report describing fugitive gangster Dawood Ibrahim's D-Company as an "India-based" criminal group. Raghoo Puri, First Secretary at India's Permanent Mission to the UN, raised these objections during a Third Committee meeting of the UN General Assembly. India argued that the report contained glaring factual inaccuracies and criticized the lack of accountability for UN special mandate holders.

The Hindu: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY | SCHEME | QUICK READ

Carbon Offsetting and Reduction Scheme for International Aviation (CORSIA)

India is yet to finalise a comprehensive national Sustainable Aviation Fuel policy with just over two months remaining before CORSIA's mandatory phase kicks in. CORSIA is a global market-based mechanism adopted by the International Civil Aviation Organization in 2016 to reduce carbon emissions from international flights. Under the scheme, airlines compensate for their international flight CO2 emissions by purchasing eligible carbon offsets.

Vajiram & Ravi: source

SOCIAL JUSTICE & WELFARE | REPORT/INDEX | QUICK READ

India ranks 100th in Global Hunger Index, behind Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka

India ranked 100th among 122 countries in the 2026 Global Hunger Index with a score of 24.1, placing it in the serious category. The report was published by German aid agency Welthungerhilfe and Irish organisation Concern Worldwide, drawing on data from 2021 to 2025. The core issue involves a debate over methodology, with the Indian government rejecting the index as a flawed private construct.

thesouthfirst.com: source

ECONOMY | SCHEME | ACT/BILL/RULES | QUICK READ

Final redemption under Sovereign Gold Bond (SGB) Scheme - Redemption Price for final redemption of SGB 2018-19 Series-II due on October 23, 2026

The final redemption is due on October 23, 2026, marking the completion of eight years from its issue date. The Reserve Bank of India announced a redemption price of Rs 14,425 per unit for the final redemption of Sovereign Gold Bond 2018-19 Series-II.

RBI: source

INFRASTRUCTURE & ENERGY | REPORT/INDEX | QUICK READ

Speedy project approvals, assured buyers key to India's 100 MT coal gasification target by 2030: Report

A report by Alvarez & Marsal titled 'Coal Gasification for Atmanirbhar Bharat' highlights key requirements for India's 2030 coal gasification target. The report was launched on Thursday at the Gasification Summit in New Delhi. India aims to gasify 100 million tonnes of coal by 2030, needing Rs 2.5-3 lakh crore in investments across 25 projects.

BusinessLine: source

DEFENCE | AGREEMENT/MOU | QUICK READ

Badr Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) 2026, Pakistan, Turkey, Qatar & Indonesia Defence Deal

Pakistan, Turkey, Qatar, and Indonesia signed the Badr Memorandum of Understanding on 21 October 2026 in Doha, Qatar. The agreement aims to strengthen defence cooperation, joint military production, research and development, and technical training. The core objective is to combine technical expertise, industrial resources, and financial capabilities to boost domestic defence industries. Turkey contributes defence technology and manufacturing experience, while Pakistan provides production facilities and personnel.

Vajiram & Ravi: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS QUICK READ

India and Uzbekistan agree to strengthen cooperation against terrorism and regional security threats

India and Uzbekistan held the 10th meeting of their Joint Working Group on Counter Terrorism in New Delhi. The meeting took place on 22 October 2026 to discuss growing global and regional security challenges. The core issue focused on combating extremism, radicalisation, terrorism financing, and the misuse of technology. The meeting was co-chaired by Dr Suhel Ajaz Khan from India's Ministry of External Affairs and Pirimkulov Gulomjon Shodmonkulovich from Uzbekistan.

gktoday.in: source

ECONOMY AGREEMENT/MOU QUICK READ

India has huge scope to expand processed food exports to UK after trade pact: TPCI

India's processed food exports to the UK have large growth potential as India accounts for only 0.6 percent of Britain's annual imports. The low market share exists despite Britain's massive annual processed food imports valued at USD 50.68 billion. India and the UK implemented a Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) on July 15 to boost trade and investment ties.

BusinessLine: source

INFRASTRUCTURE & ENERGY SCHEME QUICK READ

UPERC Approves Solar Power Projects in Uttar Pradesh under PM-KUSUM

The Uttar Pradesh Electricity Regulatory Commission approved 10 power purchase agreements covering a combined solar power capacity of 19.7 MW. These projects are approved under the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Urja Suraksha evam Utthaan Mahabhiyan scheme. The approved tariff range for electricity generated by these projects is between Rs. 2.91 and Rs. 2.99 per unit. The implementing agencies for these solar programmes are UPNEDA and UPPCL.

drishtiias.com: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY SPECIES PLACE IN NEWS QUICK READ

New Flowering Plant Species Identified in Manas National Park, Assam

Researchers from Gauhati University identified a new flowering plant species named Osbeckia assamensis in Assam. The discovery was made during floristic surveys conducted between 2021 and 2025 in Manas National Park. Osbeckia assamensis belongs to the Melastomataceae family and thrives in the grasslands of the Himalayan foothills. It is a perennial shrub growing 2 to 2.5 metres tall, featuring pink flowers, large opposite leaves, and an unbranched stem.

drishtiias.com: source

POLITY & CONSTITUTION ACT/BILL/RULES QUICK READ

Merchant Shipping Tribunal Members' Qualification Rules, 2026 Notified

The rules were recently notified by the government. The Central Government has officially notified the Merchant Shipping Tribunal Members Qualification Rules, 2026, setting the eligibility criteria for its members.

SCC Online: source

EDITORIAL WATCH

What the opinion pages argued: two or three lines each.

GS2 GS3 Unlocking Agri-Potential of FRA Lands

The Forest Rights Act, 2006 has granted millions of tribal and forest-dwelling families legal rights over land, but titles alone do not provide livelihoods. Authors propose growing pulses and oilseeds on FRA plots to turn titles into productive assets and reduce India's import dependence. Pulses and oilseeds are ideal because they adapt to rain-fed and marginal lands, raise productivity, and foster climate-resilient farming.

The Hindu

GS2 How to Break the Ration-Shop Monopoly in PDS

India's Public Distribution System provides subsidised foodgrains to millions through nearly five lakh Fair Price Shops. Geographically tied ration entitlements weakened beneficiary bargaining power and created heavy dependence on assigned dealers. Breaking the dealer monopoly requires expanding beneficiary choice, strengthening accountability, and improving foodgrain delivery. Historical challenges included leakage, corruption, storage inefficiencies, exclusion errors, and limited nutritional diversity beyond wheat and rice. Reform measures like One Nation One Ration Card empower beneficiaries to switch dealers and collect rations anywhere via Aadhaar.

ForumIAS

GS3 Indian Agriculture's Polycrisis Moment

Indian agriculture faces a polycrisis driven by geopolitical conflicts, weak monsoon, climate uncertainty, rising input costs, and water scarcity. The fossilisation of farming is evident as India's tractor population crossed 1.2 crore and fertiliser consumption reached 33.5 million tonnes in 2025-26. Heavy reliance on imported oil, gas, and fertiliser raw materials exposes Indian farming to severe external energy shocks and price volatility.

ForumIAS

GS3 Global slump: Why corporate capex in India is unlikely to rise just yet

Persistent global economic sluggishness and policy flux have brought corporate investment trends into sharp focus. An analysis of why corporate capital expenditure in India is unlikely to rise soon despite a healthy investment-to-GDP ratio. Capital expenditure by corporate firms has been weak in much of the world. But India's total investment-to-GDP ratio has been better than pre-covid and is second only to China. That said, global policy flux and unfavourable government capex weigh against strong pick-up.

Mint

GS2 Why sensitive legal language matters

The Supreme Court published a revised Handbook on Judgments and Gender, and the Karnataka High Court replaced the term visitation with parenting time. The Supreme Court was triggered to act after condemning inappropriate remarks made by an Allahabad High Court judge in a 2025 POCSO Act judgment. The core issue is that insensitive remarks persist in courts because training and word lists fail to change the deep-seated assumptions behind the words.

The Hindu

GS2 Dissent demands judicial guardrails

India witnessed widespread protests in 2026, including the summer NEET-UG agitation and autumn Special Intensive Revision electoral roll demonstrations. The executive's response relied on sweeping preventive measures, exposing a wide chasm between administrative reality and constitutional jurisprudence. Authorities used Section 163 of the BNSS, 2023, successor to CrPC Section 144, to blanket New Delhi with prohibitory orders on October 10, 2026. The mechanical application of Section 163 ignored the constitutional distinction between localized law and order and broader public order issues.

Deccan Herald

GS2 Best of Opinion: India must step up to reshape WTO to benefit Global South

Featured in the daily opinion roundup examining pressing economic, trade, and social policy issues. Editorials examine India's strategic role in reforming the WTO for the Global South, alongside domestic economic and regulatory issues. Today's editorials and columns examine delays in satellite broadband approvals, highway construction safety, India's role in WTO reforms, the RBI's rupee strategy and the struggle for women's rights

Business Standard

GS3 Data on value chain emissions will help

The policy shift has brought attention to the difficulties small businesses face in carbon tracking and the need for large firm leadership. India is set to require exporters to report emissions across their supply chains, posing compliance challenges for MSMEs. This initiative presents challenges, especially for micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs), which struggle to track emissions. Large companies are expected to take the lead in this process, developing systems for reporting.

Economic Times

GS2 Waiting for Godot in Court 1: The art of judicial absurdity in Supreme Court

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi presided over 46 petitions concerning anti-SIR protests and challenges to the Chief Election Commissioner. Court 1 performed grand administrative stewardship by issuing notices, appointing nodal counsel, and ordering CCTV preservation, while leaving the ground reality static. The author argues that centralising 40-odd time-sensitive civil liberties petitions into Court 1 created a bottleneck rather than providing immediate emergency relief.

Bar & Bench

GS3 Mint Quick Edit | SBI data breach: India's AI efforts must make cybersecurity a priority

The discovery of SBI customer data on the dark web brought cybersecurity concerns back into focus. Customer information of India's largest bank, SBI, was discovered on the dark web, exposing vulnerabilities in the financial sector's digital infrastructure. This is a wake-up call for the country to strengthen its cyber shields. India's quest for sovereign AI must focus on the financial sector's fortification too.

Mint

GS3 Rising corporate borrowings, hello!

The trend was highlighted in an editorial discussing the revival of private sector investments backed by robust economic growth and low bond yields. Public Sector Banks in India are witnessing a rise in corporate borrowings, signaling a strengthening of private sector capital expenditure driven by sectors like commercial real estate and chemicals. Key sectors driving this trend include wholesale trading, commercial real estate, and chemicals. Factors such as robust economic growth and low bond yields are contributing to expanded corporate lending.

Economic Times

GS3 Big impact of deficient monsoon

It is in the news due to the alarming deficiency in monsoon rainfall impacting national agricultural output. The editorial discusses the severe repercussions of one of the worst monsoons in 35 years, highlighting damage to Kharif crops and the vital need for Rabi season preparation. This has been among the worst monsoons in 35 years.

BusinessLine

GS3 India is within its rights to use duties others have weaponized against the Global South

The editorial argues that India is fully justified in utilizing anti-dumping duties to protect its industries against practices weaponized by major economies. A study has shown a fall in the implementation of anti-dumping duties recommended by the Directorate General of Trade Remedies. This, even as large economies have weaponized trade remedies to degrade the industrial base of the Global South.

Mint

GS3 India must avoid copying China's aggressive tax policies on private wealth and offshore assets

China recently levied a 20% income tax on offshore trusts and asset gains, alongside taxing returns on offshore insurance policies. Beijing imposed a strict 90-day window to settle unpaid tax dues dating back to 2023, reflecting aggressive enforcement. Developing economies often look to major global powers for policy cues, but India must steer clear of emulating China's tax squeeze. China's economic circumstances differ vastly as its growth has slowed, government finances face pressure, and its property market suffers a prolonged slump.

Economic Times

GS2 End the UNSC control on picking the next UN chief

The author argues that the ongoing selection process for the next UN secretary-general highlights the deep dysfunction and dominance of the P-5 veto power in the UN Security Council. The selection process requires nominations, CV submissions, vision statements, dialogues, and a series of secret straw polls where a single P-5 veto can kill a candidature. In the sixth straw poll held on October 15, two leading women candidates from Latin America—Rebeca Grynspan and Carolyn Rodrigues-Birkett—were vetoed by two P-5 members.

Hindustan Times

EXPLAINED

The concept behind the news, one or two lines each.

Knowledge Nugget | Sirpur in UNESCO's Tentative List: What makes this ancient site significant? The ancient site of Sirpur was highlighted after being added to UNESCO's tentative list of World Heritage sites. Sirpur is an ancient archaeological site in Chhattisgarh known for its multi-religious monuments, brick architecture, and historical significance as a medieval capital.

Indian Express

Why are Andhra Pradesh's civic poll nominations under the Supreme Court's scrutiny? The Supreme Court asked the Andhra Pradesh State Election Commission to defer publishing the final list of candidates for civic polls until October 25. A vacation bench heard a petition by the YSRCP alleging that violence and threats prevented its candidates from filing nomination papers.

The Hindu

Is inflation becoming more widespread? RBI's rate-setters are divided, and that's a worry Internal policy debates among members of the RBI rate-setting panel highlighted concerns over the spread of inflation. An analysis of the divisions among RBI rate-setters regarding whether inflation is becoming more widespread across the economy.

Indian Express

UN Reforms – Need & Challenges Reforming the United Nations aims to make it more effective, representative, transparent, and responsive to 21st-century realities. Calls for reform are driven by lack of equitable representation, outdated power structures, and the veto power of the P5.

ForumIAS

Pakistan, Turkey, Qatar, Indonesia sign new defence deal. Why India should pay close attention to Badr pact The signing of the new Badr defence pact between Pakistan, Turkey, Qatar, and Indonesia put it in the news. Pakistan, Turkey, Qatar, and Indonesia have signed a new multilateral defence agreement called the Badr pact.

Firstpost

The rise and rediscovery of Khajuraho's iconic medieval temples The architectural marvels remain a subject of cultural interest and heritage tourism, prompting periodic academic and popular overviews. This explainer details the historical rise, architectural significance, and eventual rediscovery of the medieval temples of Khajuraho.

Indian Express

CERT-In Advisory, MeitY Probe And Global Revocations: The eMudhra Security Story Explained The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology constituted a specialised investigation team after disclosures of a security incident in eMudhra's Public Key Infrastructure. Eight intermediate Certificate Authority certificates issued under eMudhra's global web-security banner were compromised due to cryptographic weaknesses in their private keys.

news18.com

Why SC said Section 17A of anti-corruption law does not protect public servants in bribe cases The ruling came through an judicial interpretation regarding the scope of legal protection granted to bureaucrats under anti-corruption laws. The Supreme Court held that Section 17A of the Prevention of Corruption Act does not require prior sanction to investigate public servants caught in bribery cases.
Indian Express

Drone revolution and modern warfare The strategic use of drones in recent wars across Ukraine, Lebanon, and West Asia has put the drone revolution in the news. Recent conflicts highlight how inexpensive unmanned aerial systems are reshaping modern warfare, shifting power toward industrial scale, tech adaptation, and counter-drone capabilities.
The Hindu

How exposed is India to foreign tech? India has made major progress in indigenous digital infrastructure but remains dependent on foreign-controlled technologies across critical sectors like satellite communication, navigation, cloud computing, and defence. External risks stem not only from deliberate restrictions or sanctions by foreign governments and companies, but also from technical software failures and foreign management systems.
The Hindu

What's holding up Washington's $14 bn arms sale to Taiwan? Taiwan is waiting for US President Donald Trump to approve a $14 billion arms sale to deter potential Chinese attacks. China strongly opposes US military support for Taiwan, threatening to seize the island it claims as its territory.
Economic Times

Trump's Putin Gamble: Does He Need Russia To End The Ukraine War, Or Is It Becoming A Midterm Liability? US President Donald Trump faces a political dilemma as the November 3 midterm elections approach, balancing outreach to Vladimir Putin to lower fuel prices against bipartisan criticism. High domestic fuel costs, exacerbated by the Iran war, have created urgency for the White House to demonstrate action on consumer affordability.
news18.com

ALSO IN THE NEWS

Reactions, previews and smaller stories: one line each.

- India's interest rate gap with G7 in focus as RBI weighs inflation risks: Report (Economy) Economic Times
- Mission LiFE, Meaning, Launch, Objectives, Themes, Impact (Environment & Ecology) Vajiram & Ravi
- India-Poland Bilateral Relationship (International Relations) Vajiram & Ravi
- Andhra: Low pressure over Bay of Bengal likely to intensify into cyclone by Oct 26 (Disaster Management) Hindustan Times
- Ganga Water Sharing Treaty at 30: Reimagining India-Bangladesh Partnership (International Relations) Observer Research Foundation
- Union Secretary MoSJ&E Shri Sudhansh Pant Lauds J&K's Grassroots Welfare Outreach, Whole-Of-Government Approach Against Drug Abuse (Governance & Policy) PIB
- World Polio Day 2026, Theme, Significance, India's Polio-Free Status (Health) Vajiram & Ravi
- India, Canada explore energy partnership as both sides push to seal trade deal (International Relations) Hindustan Times
- NHAI Strengthens Air Pollution Control Measures Across Delhi-NCR through Intensified Dust-Control Measures and Faster Decongestion of National Highways (Environment & Ecology) PIB
- NUSRL Ranchi seeks GI Tag for Jharkhand's Cultural Heritage -Mandar and Deoghar Peda (History, Art & Culture) Jharkhand State News
- Which Are the Latest Ramsar Sites Added to India in 2026? Check Names and Locations (Environment & Ecology) Jagran Josh
- PM Dhan Dhaanya Krishi Yojana, Features, Implementation (Agriculture & Allied) Vajiram & Ravi
- These 3 Indian destinations might soon become UNESCO World Heritage sites (History, Art & Culture) Firstpost
- J P Nadda inaugurates India Chem 2026, calls BHAVYA Rasayan Scheme a game changer for chemical sector (Economy) www.irishsun.com
- India, Poland push for stronger trade and defence ties (International Relations) Economic Times
- Nepal steps up preparations for COP31 climate summit (Environment & Ecology) Khabarhub
- Kuwait-flagged tanker carrying 21 Indian seafarers hit by projectile in Strait of Hormuz; all safe (International Relations) Times of India
- Vaigai River, Origin, Tributaries, Irrigation, Dam, Significance (Geography) Vajiram & Ravi
- Shamonda Virus, First Human Case in France, Symptoms, Preventions (Health) The Hindu
- ISRO to launch NVS-03 satellite on October 30 (Science & Technology) The Hindu
- CII urges exporters, MSMEs to tap opportunities under India-New Zealand FTA (Economy) BusinessLine
- India-US Ties: Key Takeaways On Trade Deal, Energy Cooperation And Summit Talks (International Relations) India Today
- Amrita Vishwa Vidyapeetham Presents ATL Sarthi Coimbatore Cluster's AY 2025–26 Report to NITI Aayog (Education) Amrita Vishwa Vidyapeetham
- IMF Says India Monetary Policy Should Focus on Inflation over Rupee Amid High Oil Prices (Economy) CNBC TV18
- Exclusive | Quad confirmed, Manila envoy signals likely 'Squad' talks before Trump-Xi summit (International Relations) South China Morning Post

- Indian and Australian Army Troops Continue Intensive Joint Training under Exercise AUSTRAHIND 2026 in Kerala (Defence) SSBCrack
- Two New Underground Fish Species Discovered in Assam, Shrub Rediscovered After 204 Years (Environment & Ecology) guwahati Plus News
- India at UNGA: Uphold judicial independence in IRMCT transition (International Relations) Asianet Newsable
- India-Poland defence industry dialogue to explore co-development, co-production (Defence) IANS LIVE
- COP31 urged to develop strategies for climate finance by 2035 (Environment & Ecology) chinadailyhk
- Explain the process of volcanic island formation at convergent plate boundaries. Identify the factors responsible for variations in volcanic activity along an island arc. Bring out the associated geological hazards. (Geography) Insights on India
- Climes Neutralises Carbon Emissions Through Everyday Choices (Governance & Policy) NITI Aayog
- India submits seventh national report on biodiversity to CBD (Environment & Ecology) DD News
- Courts can't suggest custodial quizzing, says Supreme Court (Polity & Constitution) Hindustan Times
- Foreign Technology Dependence: India's Strategic Risks (Science & Technology) Vajiram & Ravi
- China-Europe rail and India's long road to Eurasia (International Relations) Economic Times
- The story of India's post-election defection wave since 2022, in charts (Polity & Constitution) Mint
- Free and Fair Election is a Basic Structure of Constitution, Courts Hands Not Tied When Intervention is Necessary: SC (Polity & Constitution) TheWire.in
- The FATF and the Narcoterrorism Challenge in South Asia: Lessons from Pakistan (Internal Security) Observer Research Foundation
- Sonam Wangchuk accuses Centre of going back on assurances to Ladakh, demands U.T. with Legislature (Polity & Constitution) The Hindu
- International Organization of Legal Metrology (OIML) (Governance & Policy) ForumIAS
- Cars to brake on their own: Centre plans AEBS mandate from Oct 2030 (Governance & Policy) Times of India

COVERAGE CHECK

Items — 20 must-know, 22 Prelims facts, 42 in the news, 15 editorials, 12 explainers.

Syllabus areas in the cards — International Relations (7), Environment & Ecology (7), Polity & Constitution (6), Governance & Policy (4), Economy (4), Defence (3), Social Justice & Welfare (3), Infrastructure & Energy (3), Agriculture & Allied (2), Internal Security (1), Science & Technology (1), Health (1). **Nothing today in —** Education, Disaster Management, History, Art & Culture, Geography, Society, Ethics & Integrity.

Easy-miss watch — Marine & coastal (EEZ, UNCLOS, Blue Economy, deep sea): 2 · Digital Public Infrastructure & data governance: 2 · Political change in the neighbourhood: nothing today · Appointments to constitutional / statutory / regulatory bodies: nothing today · Defence-technology cooperation agreements: 7

Full text — 47 of 69 items were read in full from a free copy; the rest are summarised from the outlets' reports. Subscriber-only sites are never opened.

Sources in the cards — The Hindu 9, PIB 7, Economic Times 6, Hindustan Times 5, Indian Express 4, Vajiram & Ravi 3, BusinessLine 3, ForumIAS 3, Mint 3, Business Standard 2, msn.com 2, SCC Online 2, Bar & Bench 2, drishtiias.com 2

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